MODULE 9: Tools & Techniques to Verify Information

Objective
To help participants understand:
- Why verifying information is essential.
- What types of information require verification.
- Simple, practical tools for checking the authenticity of images, videos, and written content.
- How ordinary citizens can develop the habit of independently verifying information.

9.1 Why Is Information Verification Essential?

Information spreads rapidly in the digital age. However:
- Not all information is accurate.
- Not all sources are reliable.
- Not all images or videos are genuine.

Once false information has spread, it can be difficult to correct.
Verifying information before sharing is therefore one of the most effective ways to prevent its spread.

9.2 What Types of Information Should Be Verified?

It is not always possible to verify every piece of information. However, the following should be checked:
- Information about elections and voting.
- Government decisions or directives.
- Statements attributed to public figures or institutions.
- Sensitive social or civic issues.
- Emotionally charged, alarming, or sensational claims.

The guiding rule is simple: when in doubt, verify.

9.3 Source-Checking Techniques

The first step in verifying information is to check its source.

Ask yourself:
- Who provided this information?
- Is the source official or reliable?
- Can other credible sources confirm it?

DO:
- Check official websites.
- Verified social media pages.
- Established, reliable news outlets.

9.4 Tools and Techniques for Verifying Images

Images are a major source of misleading information. One useful verification method is reverse image search, which helps identify where an image has appeared before.

Useful Tools:
- Google Reverse Image Search.
- TinEye.

How It Helps:
- Identify whether an image is old.
- Check whether it has been used in a different context.

Old images are often presented as if they depict recent events.

9.5 Basic Techniques for Verifying Videos

Verifying videos can be more challenging, but several simple techniques can help.

Do:

- Find the original source of the video.
- Check whether the same video appears elsewhere.
- Cross-check its date, location, and context.
- Take screenshots of selected frames and use reverse image search.

The existence of a video does not prove that a claim is true.

9.6 Techniques for Verifying Written Content and Claims

To verify written claims:

Do:

- Pick out the specific claim and look at it on its own
- Look for an official announcement or statement
- Compare it with more than one reliable source

Warning Signs:

- "A source has said"
- "According to secret information"
- "All the media is silent"

Vague language usually signals deception

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9.7 Using Social Media Features

Many platforms have features that help you check information:

- The report option
- "Context" or "About this post" under a post
- Verified account badges
- Warning labels from the platform

Using these tools is part of our duty as citizens.

9.8 A Simple Checklist for Fact-Checking

Before you share, ask yourself these 5 questions:

1. Did this information come from a reliable source?
2. Can I find it in other trusted places?
3. Is it clear where the photo or video came from, and when it was made?
4. Is it trying to make me feel too strong an emotion?
5. Am I about to share something I am not sure about?

If you are unsure about even one question, do not share.

9.9 Why Fact-Checking Matters in Bangladesh

- Fact-checking is even more important in Bangladesh because:
- Social media is often the main source of information
- Rumors spread quickly
- False information about elections and citizens' issues can have a big effect
- The habit of checking information helps protect public trust and keeps society stable.

9.10 What We Can Do as Citizens

Do:

- Pause before you share
- Check the information
- Give priority to official information
- Warn others politely

What to Avoid:

- Sharing because of strong feelings
- Treating a screenshot or a forwarded message as true
- Commenting before checking